



Mark Scheme (Results)

Summer 2026

Pearson Edexcel International GCSE

in English Language (4EB1)

Paper 01

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General Marking Guidance

- All candidates must receive the same treatment. Examiners must mark the first candidate in exactly the same way as they mark the last.
- Mark schemes should be applied positively. Candidates must be rewarded for what they have shown they can do rather than penalised for omissions.
- Examiners should mark according to the mark scheme not according to their perception of where the grade boundaries may lie.
- There is no ceiling on achievement. All marks on the mark scheme should be used appropriately.
- All the marks on the mark scheme are designed to be awarded. Examiners should always award full marks if deserved, i.e. if the answer matches the mark scheme. Examiners should also be prepared to award zero marks if the candidate's response is not worthy of credit according to the mark scheme.
- Where some judgement is required, mark schemes will provide the principles by which marks will be awarded and exemplification may be limited.
- When examiners are in doubt regarding the application of the mark scheme to a candidate's response, the team leader must be consulted.
- Crossed out work should be marked UNLESS the candidate has replaced it with an alternative response.

Specific Marking Guidance

When deciding how to reward an answer, examiners should consult both the indicative content and the associated marking grid(s). When using a levels-based mark scheme, the 'best fit' approach should be used.

- Examiners should first decide which descriptor most closely matches the answer and place it in that level.
- The mark awarded within the level will be decided based on the quality of the answer and will be modified according to how securely all bullet points are displayed at that level.
- Indicative content is exactly that – they are factual points that candidates are likely to use to construct their answer.
- It is possible for an answer to be constructed without mentioning some or all of these points, as long as they provide alternative responses to the indicative content that fulfils the requirements of the question. It is the examiner's responsibility to apply their professional judgement to the

candidate's response in determining if the answer fulfils the requirements of the question.

Placing a mark within a level

- Examiners should first decide which descriptor most closely matches the answer and place it in that level. The mark awarded within the level will be decided based on the quality of the answer and will be modified according to how securely all bullet points are displayed at that level.
- In cases of uneven performance, the points above will still apply. Candidates will be placed in the level that best describes their answer according to the descriptors in that level. Marks will be awarded towards the top or bottom of that level depending on how they have evidenced each of the descriptor bullet points.
- If the candidate's answer meets the requirements fully, markers should be prepared to award full marks within the level. The top mark in the level is used for work that is as good as can realistically be expected within that level.

AO1	Read and understand a variety of texts, selecting and interpreting information, ideas and perspectives.
AO2	Understand and analyse how writers use linguistic and structural devices to achieve their effects.
AO3	Explore links and connections between writers' ideas and perspectives, as well as how these are conveyed.
AO4	Communicate effectively and imaginatively, adapting form, tone and register of writing for specific purposes and audiences.
AO5	Write clearly, using a range of vocabulary and sentence structures, with appropriate paragraphing and accurate spelling, grammar and punctuation.

SECTION A: Reading

Text One

Question Number	AO1 Read and understand a variety of texts, selecting and interpreting information, ideas and perspectives.	Mark
1	One mark for any one of the following: • distract children (from learning/from other real-world experiences) • they drain valuable time • (can give us) FOMO (fear of missing out) • lead to (constant) comparisons with others • feeling low • (can be used for) cyberbullying • can be used for) targeting vulnerable teens	(1)

Question Number	AO1 Read and understand a variety of texts, selecting and interpreting information, ideas and perspectives.	Mark
2	One mark for any one of the following: • give more guidance for parents/teachers/those in pastoral roles • talk to young people about their screen-time usage • talk to young people about how it makes them feel • help by putting limits on screen time • making rules • putting away phones at an agreed time/charging overnight in the kitchen/charging overnight in another room • education about online safety/social media apps/algorithms • education about the constant marketing of products and “influencing” through posts • schools can also help by creating/enforcing no-phone policies/there should be a no-phone rule	(1)

Question Number	Answer	Mark
3	Reward responses that explain how the writer presents her ideas about smartphones. Responses may include: - the opening 'scrolling through social media' immediately shows the reader that the writer is someone who is familiar with social platforms - the detailed list of statistics, 'six hours for 8-10-year-olds, nine hours for 11-14-year-olds and 7.5 hours for 15-18-year-olds', shows that she has done research and adds credibility - the adjective 'shocking' and its use in the short sentence, 'These are shocking numbers.' which emphasises how surprising and alarming these figures are - by using 'Like many people' the writer is showing the reader that she is the same as the majority of readers - the use of a balanced argument: 'am surprised' and 'But I also feel uncomfortable' shows the reader that she is a reasonable person and that her views will not be extreme - the hyperbole, 'terrible for humanity', shows how over-dramatic some attitudes to smartphones are - the adjectives 'useful, practical' emphasise the positive aspects of smartphones - the noun 'tools' presents the idea that smartphones are not toys or primarily for entertainment - the adverb 'definitely' clearly shows that there are negatives to smartphones - the list (throughout the paragraph) of the problems smartphone usage causes, shows the reader that the issue is serious - the use of dates in reference to mental health research: '2010', '2017' adds credibility to the arguments about the impacts on mental health - the use of the adjective 'crude' shows that the writer does not approve of a ban on smartphones for	

	under-16s. It suggests that the reactions are simple and not well thought out • the writer references research 'decades of public health research' to support the idea that banning smartphones will not work • the abstract nouns 'freedom' and 'choice' present a positive and optimistic alternative • the tricolon, 'parents, teachers and those in pastoral roles' highlights the importance of these people in helping educate young people about smartphones • the writer gives suggestions that sound reasonable and achievable, 'Education about online safety' and she presents positive outcomes: 'focus on learning and in-person experiences' • the inclusion of the anecdote 'My home state...' presents a place that is banning social media access for young people. The writer offers no comment, so the reader is left to wonder if this is a good idea • the quotation from Paul Renner could seem rather patronising: 'because of that we have to step in for them' • the use of the alliterative idiom 'wild west' suggests how chaotic reactions were to smartphones in the past • the final sentence is less positive and the use of 'worrying' suggests it is both concerning (and perhaps a warning).	(10)
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Question 3		
Level	Mark	AO2 Understand and analyse how writers use linguistic and structural devices to achieve their effects.
	0	No rewardable material.
Level 1	1–2	• Basic identification and little understanding of the language and/or structure used by writers to achieve effects. • The use of references is limited.
Level 2	3–4	• Some understanding of and comment on language and structure and how these are used by writers to achieve effects, including use of vocabulary. • The selection of references is valid, but not developed.
Level 3	5–6	• Clear understanding and explanation of language and structure and how these are used by writers to achieve effects, including use of vocabulary and sentence structure. • The selection of references is appropriate and relevant to the points being made.
Level 4	7–8	• Thorough understanding and exploration of language and structure and how these are used by writers to achieve effects, including use of vocabulary, sentence structure and other language features. • The selection of references is detailed, appropriate and fully supports the points being made.
Level 5	9–10	• Perceptive understanding and analysis of language and structure and how these are used by writers to achieve effects, including use of vocabulary, sentence structure and other language features. • The selection of references is discriminating and clarifies the points being made.

Text Two

Question Number	AO1 Read and understand a variety of texts, selecting and interpreting information, ideas and perspectives.	Mark
4	One mark for any one of the following: • no boarding pass • no email access • no banking app • no contacts/no way to contact anyone • no map • no Uber app • no way to tell the time • she would have nothing/she was not able to access her apps	(1)

Question Number	AO1 Read and understand a variety of texts, selecting and interpreting information, ideas and perspectives.	Mark
5	One mark each for any two of the following: • it was uncomfortable • she was unable to check her phone as she would do normally/she could not go on her phone • she stared (numbly) into space • if she saw something she liked, she couldn't take a photo of it • she had to remember it with her brain • she had zero idea of what was going on in the news • she did not know if anyone was trying to contact her • (it was like) a phantom itch • she could not swipe through TikTok • she had to mentally swipe through her own memories • she couldn't listen to podcasts • she sat with her thoughts	(2)

Question Number	Answer	Mark
6	Reward responses that explain how the writer presents her experiences of being without a phone. Responses may include: - the opening sentence is deliberately dramatic and enigmatic, 'It happened while I was on a plane to Zagreb in Croatia.', which would catch the reader's attention - the use of the colloquial 'randomly glitching' shows the writer is well aware of her intended audience - the use of ellipsis '... died completely' emphasises the shock the writer feels - the adverb, 'maniacally', presents a familiar response to the reader who may have had similar experiences - the short sentence 'Life goes on.' seems optimistic - the list of problems 'no boarding pass...' creates tension. This is reinforced by the repetition of 'no' - the use of a dramatic verb, 'hurtling', adds to the sense of panic, encouraging the reader to appreciate her predicament - the description, 'logistical panic', suggests how much the writer is reliant on her phone - the repetition of '72 hours' shows how much this has had an impact on her. Readers might sympathise or think she is being over-dramatic - the alliteration of 'little light-up' presents the phone as both insignificant and a technological marvel that can be reassuring - she includes (some) statistics '58 times' to show that we all spend too long on phones - she dismisses the discussions about smartphones: 'because it's too late' - the shocking sentence: 'Ten-year-olds have iPhones now.' supports the idea that it is too late - she describes her first day in Zagreb as 'uncomfortable, obviously'. The use of the adverb 'obviously' suggests that she is writing for a similar audience to herself	

	- the descriptions of what she does without her phone are supposed to elicit sympathy from the reader: 'stared numbly', 'remember it with my brain', 'sat with my thoughts'. However, some readers may think she sounds childish or churlish - the use of the simile 'like a phantom itch' clearly conveys how irritating the experience is - the use of 'swiped through TikTok' and 'swipe through my own memories' shows how reliant she is on her phone - the tricolon: 'reading... visiting... chewing' emphasises the range of different experiences she had which she would not have had if she had her phone - the phrase 'really savouring...' suggests an enjoyable experience – again one she would not have had if she was on her phone - the short sentence 'I really missed having a phone.' shows her reliance on her phone and her deep sense of loss - her description of a phone-free life 'taxis have to be booked at actual ranks', 'have to check maps', 'buy a paper train ticket' makes it sound very difficult - the use of 'frightening' and 'scary' shows how important the writer thinks phones have become - the rhetorical question 'but what would have happened if I had?' is designed to make the reader imagine the worst and sympathise with the writer's situation - the metaphor 'immediately plugged back into the world' shows how isolated the writer felt without a phone and presents the world as a technical entity. Some readers may sympathise with this - the tricolon, 'scrolling! Googling things! Absorbing pointless information', is used to suggest that the writer has not changed her habits - the final paragraph presents a rather negative view of the impact of phones: 'None of us could', 'locked into this life', 'no easy way'.	(10)
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Question 6		
Level	Mark	AO2 Understand and analyse how writers use linguistic and structural devices to achieve their effects.
	0	No rewardable material.
Level 1	1–2	• Basic identification and little understanding of the language and/or structure used by writers to achieve effects. • The use of references is limited.
Level 2	3–4	• Some understanding of and comment on language and structure and how these are used by writers to achieve effects, including use of vocabulary. • The selection of references is valid, but not developed.
Level 3	5–6	• Clear understanding and explanation of language and structure and how these are used by writers to achieve effects, including use of vocabulary and sentence structure. • The selection of references is appropriate and relevant to the points being made.
Level 4	7–8	• Thorough understanding and exploration of language and structure and how these are used by writers to achieve effects, including use of vocabulary, sentence structure and other language features. • The selection of references is detailed, appropriate and fully supports the points being made.
Level 5	9–10	• Perceptive understanding and analysis of language and structure and how these are used by writers to achieve effects, including use of vocabulary, sentence structure and other language features. • The selection of references is discriminating and clarifies the points being made.

Question Number	Indicative content
7	Responses may include the following points: Text One • gives some alarming statistics about teenagers' use of phones: 'six hours for 8-10-year-olds' • presents a positive perspective: 'useful, practical tools for communication and connection' • identifies the issues with smartphones: 'distract children', 'drain valuable time' • refers to the impacts on mental health: 'increases in depression' • suggests that banning smartphones for under-16s is not the solution: 'People are entitled...', 'banning phones wouldn't prepare teens for a world increasingly reliant on tech' • presents her suggestions: 'We need more guidance for parents, teachers and those in pastoral roles', 'Adults can help by putting limits on screen time or making rules' • suggests that smartphones are not entirely to blame for the problems: 'but what teens are using them for', and that social media companies are to blame 'should be compelled to keep certain apps unavailable to younger users' • is reassuring: 'maintain the positive aspects of this technology while reducing the negative consequences'. General points candidates may make on the whole of Text One • uses first-person • uses inclusive pronouns: 'we', 'our' • uses experts/statistics • presents (some) positive aspects of smartphone usage. Text Two • presents a personal experience: 'It happened while I was on a plane to Zagreb in Croatia.' • shows the practical problems of not having a phone: 'no boarding pass, no email access', 'no banking app' • shows that the writer thinks it is too late to control smartphone usage: 'Ten-year-olds have iPhones now', 'our constant companions' • shows how reliant the writer is on her phone: 'I instead just stared numbly into space' • shows she can adapt: 'actually started to get used to it' • presents how unenjoyable it was: 'I really missed having a phone', 'not a world that's built for phone-free life'

- presents her experience without a phone as confusing and alarming: 'taxis have to be booked at actual ranks', 'You have to check maps in order to get to a location', 'remember the easiest route back', 'what would have happened if I had?'
- offers a rather pessimistic view of the use of phones: 'even if I wanted to spend less time on my phone, I actually couldn't', 'locked into this life'.

General points candidates may make on the whole of Text Two

- it is a first-person account
- presents how difficult life is without a phone
- is informal in style/tone
- uses inclusive pronouns: 'we', 'our'.

Points of comparison

- Text One is about teenagers' use of smartphones/Text Two is about problems when you do not have a working smartphone
- Text One uses experts to support ideas/Text Two uses personal experience to present ideas
- Text One talks about the damage that over-using smartphones can cause/Text Two is about how much we rely on smartphones and how they enhance our lives
- Text One suggests possible guidance and solutions/Text Two suggests that people's behaviour cannot be changed now
- both texts show that there are positive aspects of smartphones
- both texts show that the writers use smartphones a lot
- both texts show how important smartphones are for communication
- both texts are informative/persuasive
- both texts clearly convey the writers' ideas and perspectives.

Reward all valid points.

Question 7		
Level	Mark	AO3 Explore links and connections between writers' ideas and perspectives, as well as how these are conveyed.
	0	No rewardable material.
Level 1	1–3	- The response does not compare the texts. - Description of writers' ideas and perspectives, including theme, language and/or structure. - The use of references is limited.
Level 2	4–6	- The response considers obvious comparisons between the texts. - Comment on writers' ideas and perspectives, including theme, language and/or structure. - The selection of references is valid, but not developed. NB: candidates who have considered only ONE text may only achieve a mark up to the top of Level 2
Level 3	7–9	- The response considers a range of comparisons between the texts. - Explanation of writers' ideas and perspectives, including theme, language and/or structure. - The selection of references is appropriate and relevant to the points being made.
Level 4	10–12	- The response considers a wide range of comparisons between the texts. - Exploration of writers' ideas and perspectives, including how theme, language and/or structure are used across the texts. - References are balanced across both texts and fully support the points being made.
Level 5	13–15	- The response considers a varied and comprehensive range of comparisons between the texts. - Analysis of writers' ideas and perspectives, including how theme, language and/or structure are used across the texts. - References are balanced across both texts; they are discriminating and fully support the points being made.

SECTION B: Reading and Writing

Question Number	Indicative content
8	A suitable register for a talk to peers should be adopted. Candidates should address all areas. The following are some points that candidates may make but there are other possibilities. Some candidates may interpret the task more widely and use other examples than those mentioned in the passages. Positive ways • to communicate/to stay in touch • for emails • for tickets/travel • buying things • to tell the time • for entertainment • to take photos • for maps • to make life easier Negative aspects • teenagers/we all spend too much time on smartphones • they are a distraction • they can impact on education • they can prevent/stop face-to-face interaction • they are a waste of time • they can negatively affect mental health • cyberbullying/bullying • they can cause depression • social media apps can be harmful/addictive • dangers of influencing through posts • big tech companies focus their apps on young people • we rely on smartphones too much • we struggle to do everyday activities without a smartphone • they are addictive Advice to help overcome the problems with smartphones • ban them for teenagers/in schools • offer advice to parents/guardians and teachers • set time limits • leave smartphones in another room • give advice about online safety • petition governments about social media platforms • have a back-up for important information/documents on phones • find things to do that do not require the smartphone • learn (new) skills such as map-reading • do not rely on smartphones. Reward all valid points.

Question 8

Level	Mark	AO1 Read and understand a variety of texts, selecting and interpreting information, ideas and perspectives.
	0	No rewardable material.
Level 1	1–2	• Selection and interpretation of the given bullet points is limited. • Includes a small number of points with some relevance. • Demonstrates a limited ability to locate and retrieve information and ideas.
Level 2	3–4	• Selection and interpretation of the given bullet points is valid, but not developed. • Gives some relevant points. • Brings in some relevant information and ideas.
Level 3	5–6	• Selection and interpretation of the given bullet points is appropriate and relevant to the points being made. • Offers a reasonable number of relevant points. • Shows secure appreciation of information and ideas.
Level 4	7–8	• Selection and interpretation of the given bullet points is appropriate, detailed and fully supports the points being made. • Offers a good number of relevant points. • Makes well-focused comments about information and ideas.
Level 5	9–10	• Selection and interpretation of the given bullet points is apt and is persuasive in clarifying the points being made. • Offers a wide range of relevant points. • Presents well-focused comments with perceptive references to information and ideas.

Question 8		
Level	Mark	AO4 Communicate effectively and imaginatively, adapting form, tone and register of writing for specific purposes and audiences.
	0	No rewardable material.
Level 1	1–2	• Communication is at a basic level, and limited in clarity. • Little awareness is shown of the purpose of the writing and the intended reader. • Little awareness of form, tone and register.
Level 2	3–4	• Communicates in a broadly appropriate way. • Shows some grasp of the purpose and of the expectations/requirements of the intended reader. • Straightforward use of form, tone and register.
Level 3	5–7	• Communicates clearly. • Clear sense of purpose and understanding of the expectations/requirements of the intended reader. • Appropriate use of form, tone and register.
Level 4	8–10	• Communicates successfully. • A secure realisation of purpose and the expectations/requirements of the intended reader. • Effective use of form, tone and register.
Level 5	11–12	• Communication is perceptive and subtle. • Task is sharply focused on purpose and the expectations/requirements of the intended reader. • Sophisticated use of form, tone and register.

Question 8		
Level	Mark	AO5 Write clearly, using a range of vocabulary and sentence structures, with accurate spelling, paragraphing, grammar and punctuation.
	0	No rewardable material.
Level 1	1–2	- Expresses information and ideas, with limited use of structural and grammatical features. - Uses basic vocabulary, often misspelt. - Uses punctuation with basic control, creating undeveloped, often repetitive, sentence structures.
Level 2	3–4	- Expresses and orders information and ideas; uses paragraphs and a range of structural and grammatical features. - Uses some correctly spelt vocabulary, e.g. words with regular patterns such as prefixes, suffixes, double consonants. - Uses punctuation with some control, creating a range of sentence structures, including coordination and subordination.
Level 3	5–6	- Develops and manages appropriate information and ideas using structural and grammatical features deliberately with accurate paragraphing. - Uses a varied and selective vocabulary, including words with irregular patterns, with occasional spelling errors. - Uses a range of accurate and varied punctuation for clarity, adapting sentence structures for effect.
Level 4	7–8	- Manipulates complex ideas, utilising a range of structural and grammatical features to support coherence and cohesion. - Uses extensive vocabulary strategically; rare spelling errors do not detract from overall meaning. - Punctuates writing with accuracy to aid emphasis and precision, using a range of sentence structures accurately and selectively to achieve particular effects.

SECTION C: Writing

Question Number	Indicative content
9	As no audience is specified, the examiner is assumed to be the audience. Candidates are free to agree or disagree with the statement and may present a variety of arguments. Content may include references to: as individuals we have the right to decide what we do with our lives; how can the people in charge decide what is good for us or beneficial; most people make sensible choices; people need rules or laws to control society; if there were no rules some people would waste time doing things that are not beneficial; it is debatable whether some activities do no harm to others; some people make bad choices. Examiners should be open to a wide range of interpretation.

Question Number	Indicative content
10	No indicative content can be specified, since candidates may choose to interpret the title as they wish. Candidates should be rewarded for such qualities as a sense of drama, vivid description, excitement or suspense. NB: Explicit reference to the title may not be mentioned until the end of the story. Examiners should be open to a wide range of interpretation.

Question Number	Indicative content
11	Candidates may choose a range of views (which may be real or imaginary). Answers may include descriptions of the view and what they saw and the effects it had on them. Candidates should be rewarded for their powers to evoke a sense of what can be seen and its effects, using effective vocabulary. Examiners should be open to a wide range of interpretation.

Questions 9, 10 and 11

Level	Mark	AO4 Communicate effectively and imaginatively, adapting form, tone and register of writing for specific purposes and audiences.
	0	No rewardable material.
Level 1	1–4	• Communication is at a basic level, and limited in clarity. • Little awareness is shown of the purpose of the writing and the intended reader. • Little awareness of form, tone and register.
Level 2	5–8	• Communicates in a broadly appropriate way. • Shows some grasp of the purpose and of the expectations/requirements of the intended reader. • Straightforward use of form, tone and register.
Level 3	9–12	• Communicates clearly. • Clear sense of purpose and understanding of the expectations/requirements of the intended reader. • Appropriate use of form, tone and register.
Level 4	13–16	• Communicates successfully. • A secure realisation of purpose and the expectations/requirements of the intended reader. • Effective use of form, tone and register.
Level 5	17–20	• Communication is perceptive and subtle. • Task is sharply focused on purpose and the expectations/requirements of the intended reader. • Sophisticated use of form, tone and register.

Questions 9, 10 and 11		
Level	Mark	A05: Write clearly, using a range of vocabulary and sentence structures, with appropriate paragraphing and accurate spelling, grammar and punctuation.
	0	No rewardable material.
Level 1	1–2	- Expresses information and ideas, with limited use of structural and grammatical features. - Uses basic vocabulary, often misspelt. - Uses punctuation with basic control, creating undeveloped, often repetitive, sentence structures.
Level 2	3–4	- Expresses and orders information and ideas; uses paragraphs and a range of structural and grammatical features. - Uses some correctly spelt vocabulary, e.g. words with regular patterns such as prefixes, suffixes, double consonants. - Uses punctuation with some control, creating a range of sentence structures, including coordination and subordination.
Level 3	5–6	- Develops and connects appropriate information and ideas; structural and grammatical features and paragraphing make the meaning clear. - Uses a varied vocabulary and spells words containing irregular patterns correctly. - Uses accurate and varied punctuation, adapting sentence structures as appropriate.
Level 4	7–8	- Manages information and ideas, with structural and grammatical features used cohesively and deliberately across the text. - Uses a wide, selective vocabulary with only occasional spelling errors. - Positions a range of punctuation for clarity, managing sentence structures for deliberate effect.
Level 5	9–10	- Manipulates complex ideas, utilising a range of structural and grammatical features to support coherence and cohesion. - Uses extensive vocabulary strategically; rare spelling errors do not detract from overall meaning. - Punctuates writing with accuracy to aid emphasis and precision, using a range of sentence structures accurately and selectively to achieve particular effects.